divisions of these orthodoxies and the resulting, periodically violent contests for intellectual, juridical, and politico-economic sway, were especially legible in the epigraphic programs on monumental architecture: specific Qur'anic inscriptions and Hadiths came to be appropriated by some *madhhab*s to express their distinctive theologies.[5] As a result, some architectural foundations also proclaimed their sectarian affiliations through their epigraphic programs, as was the case for the Jam-Firuzkuh *minar*.[6] The ensuing examination traces the dialogue between the architecture of the Firuzkuh Shansabanis and the *specific* cultural geography they inhabited, which was one among several cultural–geographical zones in the region now bounded by the nation-state of Afghanistan (cf. Chapter 1). Ultimately, an apprehension of the role of architectural patronage in constructing an empire – literally and figuratively – is important not only for elites emerging from transhumance/nomadism, but for *all* historical state-builders.

The ensuing chapter encompasses Shansabani architectural patronage up to the definitive conquest of Ghazna in AH 568–569/1173–1174 CE, to which date the famous *minar* of Jam-Firuzkuh has been convincingly reassigned (see below). The aggregation of the corresponding architectural corpora is justifiable not only due to this significant historical event, but also by the locations and characteristics of the surviving buildings: the Chisht and Gharjistan complexes and the Jam-Firuzkuh *minar* were new, monumental foundations located within the broader architectural culture of Khurasan – at the eastern edges of the Persianate world – with substantial and extremely meaningful epigraphic programs evincing their localities' palpable participation in the theological and political developments throughout the eastern Islamic lands. Meanwhile, the Shansabani vestiges at Ghazna and Bust-Lashkari Bazar, in the Zabul–Zamindawar corridor (map, p. xvi), were altogether of a different order, being primarily interventions in the architectural fabric of Ghaznavid-period palace complexes, rather than new constructions per se (see Chapter 5). The distinguishable and localized historical geographies of these contiguous areas, and their overall significance for the Shansabanis as a confederacy, are best understood by means of clustering and juxtaposing these architectural groups.

Gharjistan, Chisht, and Imperial Firuzkuh

As is to be expected after our previous searches for even brief, contemporary textual descriptions of Shansabani-patronized architecture (cf. Chapters 2 and 3), little information is forthcoming in written sources. The lengthy section XVII of Juzjani's *Tabaqat*, with many chapters on the reigns and activities of the Shansabani *malik*s and sultans of Ghur and